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# Paramaribo Birth Certificates (1828-1921) Data Description

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## 1. Introduction

In 1828 in the Dutch colony of Suriname a civil registry was introduced according to the Dutch civil registration model (which in turn was based on the model introduced during the First French Republic). Suriname is a former Dutch plantation colony on the northern coast of South America, which became an independent country in 1975. During colonial times, it consisted of one city, Paramaribo, and a varying number of rural districts.

Unlike in the Netherlands, the civil registry did not immediately apply to the entire population. Two groups of people were not registered. First, people in slavery were excluded, they were noted down in the separate slave registers. Only after they were freed from slavery did the enter into the civil registry, which was for the fast majority of enslaved people after the abolition of slavery on July 1, 1863. Second, people living outside of the colonial context were not registered either. This included most of the inhabitants of the interior who were missing from the civil registry until after the Second World War. Accordingly, maroons and indigenous people were only registered if they had a child or died in Paramaribo or the colonial districts, or if they married someone who was already registered.

Free residents of Suriname were legally obliged to report every birth, death, marriage, acknowledgement, and divorce to a registrar. In this database you will find the birth certificates issued in Suriname´s capital city Paramaribo for the period 1828-1921 as recorded by the registrar. The birth certificates contain information on the birth, the newborn child, the parents, the informant, and the two witnesses. The birth certificate release ends in 1921 due to privacy protection.

For the interested public, the information from this release has already been made available on the website of the National Archives of Suriname (NAS) in a searchable format, where also the scans of the original certificates may be found. The present release contains additional information in a structured data-base format on for example ages, places, occupations, and illiteracy.

## 2. Files

The database consists of Paramaribo_Birth_Certificates_V1.0 stored as a .csv according to the open standards.

- Commas (,) as separators
- Quotation marks (“ ”) to signal text fields
- Stored in UTF-8

Paramaribo_Birth_Certificates_V1.0 contains information derived from 63,240 Paramaribo birth certificates for the period 1828-1921. Each row in the data represents a unique birth certificate.

The second file contains this data description, stored as a pdf.

## 3. Data quality

The current release builds on a large citizen science project organized and overseen by the Historical Database Suriname and the Caribbean (HDSC) project. Hundreds of citizen scientists transcribed the Paramaribo birth certificates in a collaborative effort on the Dutch citizen science platform Het Volk. To ensure high quality transcription, each certificate had been transcribed by two citizen scientists independently and checked by a third more senior citizen scientist and corrected if necessary.

The readability of the certificates and the quality of the scans is generally high and allows for straightforward transcription. However, in some cases certificates were damaged by for instance ink corrosion, and the citizen scientists were asked to add the symbol “@” for variables and letters that could not be read. The symbol “#”, in contrast, is used for variables that were not available on the certificates. To get as much information from the damaged certificates as possible, we initiated a so-called puzzle project for senior citizen scientists in which quite some time and effort was invested.

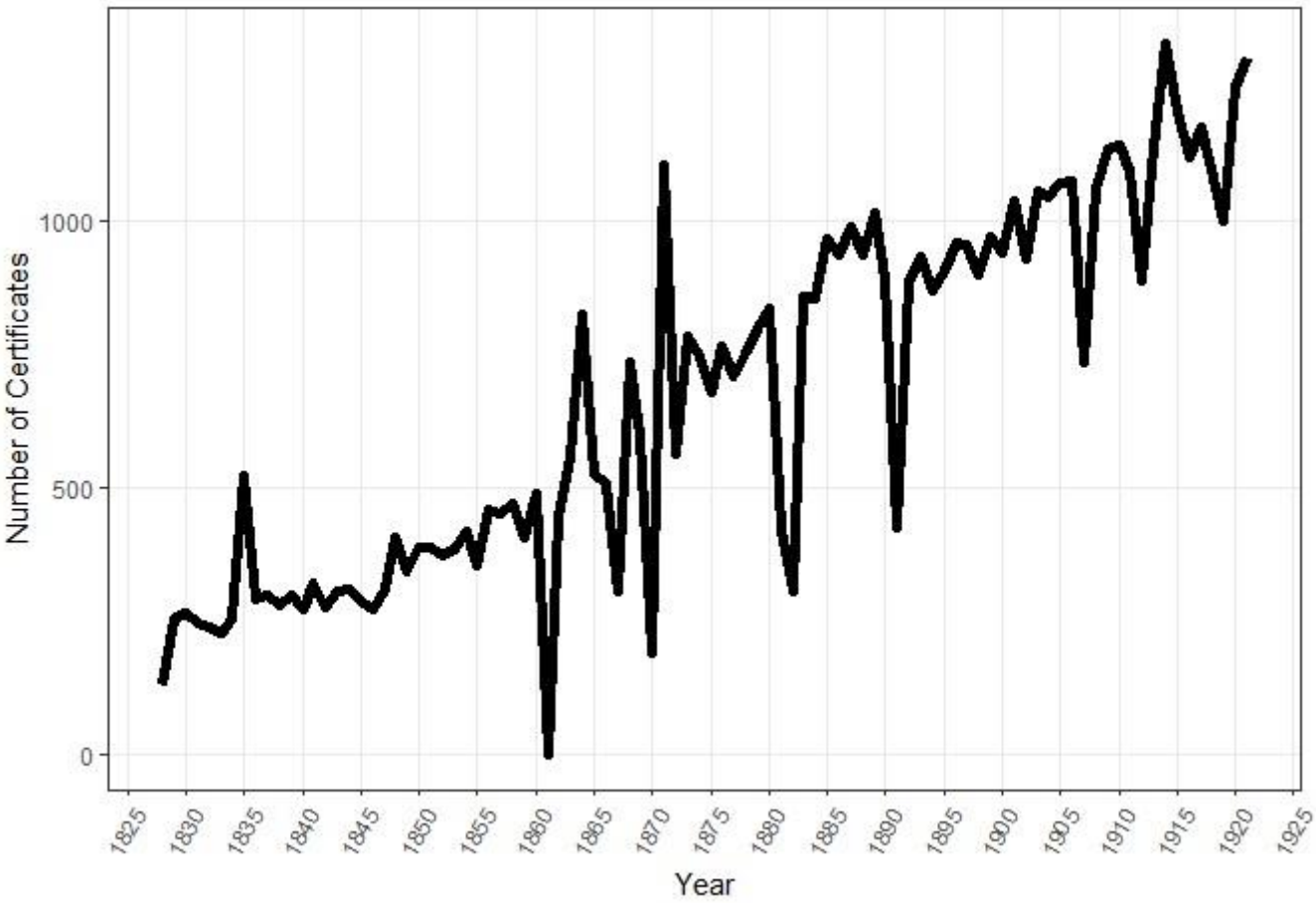
To err is human, and even though each certificate has been transcribed and controlled by three citizen scientists, transcription errors may occur occasionally. Those errors are most likely to occur for names because those are most difficult to read and to transcribe. In the future, we aim to correct for transcription mistakes.

Nevertheless, the quality of the transcription is deemed to be very high. For the year 1835, 243 birth certificates were by accident entered into the transcription loop twice which enables us to judge transcription quality of the certificates in general. The child´s sex differed only in 2 cases (<1%), and the informant´s age only in 5 cases (2%) between the transcriptions of the identical certificates. The child´s first name differed in 41 cases and the informant´s last name in 42 cases (17% each), but most differing names only differed by one or two letters (for instance Isaak/Isaac and Wannen/Wanner).

A final remark concerns the completeness of the certificates release. As can be seen in Figure 1, which shows the number of certificates per year, birth certificates in several years have only been partly preserved and are therefore missing. This concerns the years 1867 (May-November), 1870 (January-September), 1872 (May-August), 1881 (January-March and June-October), 1882 (January-August), 1891 (June-December), 1907 (September-December), and 1912 (May-July). For the year 1861, no birth certificates have been preserved at all. We aim to add currently missing certificates as soon as possible. As mentioned before, for the year 1835 most

certificates have been entered twice, but we decided to keep them in the release for researchers to judge the transcription quality themselves. Finally, Figure 1 demonstrates, that the number of Paramaribo birth certificates and births increases steadily over time from on average below 500 before the abolition of slavery in 1863 to around 1000 on average in the 20th century.

*Figure 1: The number of Paramaribo birth certificates per year, 1828-1921*



## 4. Variable overview

*Table A1. Variable overview of the variables in Paramaribo_Birth_Certificates_V1.0*

| Category | Variable | Description | Type |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Certificate** | id | Unique certificate identifier | constructed |
| | original_scanid | Scan identifier | constructed |
| | inventory_number | Inventory number from National Archive Suriname | constructed |
| | projectid | Project entry identifier | constructed |
| | folio | Folio number of the birth certificate | controlled |
| | cert_date | Date the certificate was issued | controlled |
| | cert_place | Place the certificate was issued | standardized |
| **Informant** | inf_fname | The first name of the informant | unaltered |
| | inf_prefix | The surname prefix of the informant | standardized |
| | inf_sname | The last name of the informant | unaltered |
| | inf_age | Age of the informant | standardized |
| | inf_occ | Occupation of the informant | unaltered |
| | inf_place | Address of the informant | unaltered |
| | inf_otherinfo | Other information concerning the informant | unaltered |
| | inf_sig | Whether informant was able to sign the certificate | constructed |
| | inf_sig_other | Other information about the informants' signature | unaltered |
| | inf_pres | Whether informant was present at birth | constructed |
| | inf_pres_other | Other information about the informant's presence | unaltered |
| **Birth** | birth_date | Date of birth | controlled |
| | birth_daypart | Part of the day the child was born | standardized |
| | birth_hour | Hour of the day the child was born | standardized |
| | birth_place | Place the child was born | unaltered |
| **Child** | child_sex | The sex of the newborn child | standardized |
| | child_fname | First name of the newborn child | unaltered |
| | child_prefix | Surname prefix of the newborn child | constructed |
| | child_sname | Last name of the newborn child | constructed |
| **Mother** | moth_fname | The first name of the mother | unaltered |
| | moth_prefix | The surname prefix of the mother | standardized |
| | moth_sname | The last name of the mother | unaltered |
| | moth_occ | Occupation of the mother | unaltered |
| | moth_place | Address of the mother | unaltered |
| | moth_otherinfo | Other information concerning the mother | unaltered |
| **Father** | fath_fname | The first name of the father | constructed |
| | fath_prefix | The surname prefix of the father | constructed |
| | fath_sname | The last name of the father | constructed |
| **Witness 1** | witn_fname_1 | The first name of the first witness | unaltered |
| | witn_prefix_1 | The surname prefix of the first witness | standardized |
| | witn_sname_1 | The last name of the first witness | unaltered |
| | witn_age_1 | Age of the first witness | standardized |
| | witn_occ_1 | Occupation of the first witness | unaltered |
| | witn_place_1 | Address of the first witness | unaltered |
| | witn_sig_1 | Whether first witness was able to sign the certificate | constructed |
| | witn_sig_other_1 | Other information about the first witness´ signature | unaltered |
| **Witness 2** | witn_fname_2 | The first name of the second witness | unaltered |
| | witn_prefix_2 | The surname prefix of the second witness | standardized |
| | witn_sname_2 | The last name of the second witness | unaltered |
| | witn_age_2 | Age of the second witness | standardized |
| | witn_occ_2 | Occupation of the second witness | unaltered |
| | witn_place_2 | Address of the second witness | unaltered |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| witn_sig_2 | Whether second witness was able to sign certificate | constructed |
| witn_sig_other_2 | Other information about second witness´ signature | unaltered |
| notes_all | All notifications added by the clerk on the side of the certificate | unaltered |

# A. Extensive variable description

## id
Unique certificate identifier which is made up of the archive number (2.10.61), the inventory number, the scan number, and whether the certificate is located on the right or left side of the scan.

## original_scanid
Unique scan identifier. Each scan typically contains two birth certificates. The scan identifier can be used to easily find certificates which are available online open access with the National Archive of Suriname.

## inventory_number
The inventory number assigned by the National Archive of Suriname.

## projectid
Paramaribo birth certificates were transcribed in several badges which have their own project entry identifier.

## folio
Folio number as stated on the birth certificate. Folio numbers were corrected if necessary for which we used an algorithm.

## cert_date
Date the certificate was issued as stated on the birth certificate. Illogical dates were cross-checked with the birth date and corrected manually.

## cert_place
Place the certificate was issued as stated on the birth certificate. Certificate places were standardized. As this release is from the main city Paramaribo, more than 98% of the certificates were issued here.

## inf_fname
Informant´s first name as stated on the birth certificate.

## inf_prefix
Informant´s surname prefix as stated on the birth certificate. Incorrectly looking prefixes were corrected manually.

## inf_sname
Informant´s last name as stated on the birth certificate.

## inf_age
Informant´s age as stated on the birth certificate. Impossible ages (for instance 333) were corrected manually.

## inf_occ
Informant´s occupation as stated on the birth certificate [in Dutch].

## inf_place
Informant´s address as stated on the birth certificate.

## inf_otherinfo
Additional information concerning the informant as stated on the birth certificate. For instance, it often contains information on whether the informant is the father of the newborn child [in Dutch].

## inf_sig
Constructed variable based on whether the informant was able to sign the birth certificate and whether the informant was not able to sign the certificate because of illiteracy or for another reason.

## inf_sig_other
Additional information on the informant´s (in)ability to sign the birth certificate [in Dutch].

## inf_pres
Constructed variable on whether the informant was present during birth.

## inf_pres_other
Additional information on the informant´s presence/absence during birth. For example, it is stated whether the mother was the informant herself [in Dutch].

## birth_date
Date of birth as stated on the birth certificate. Illogical dates were cross-checked with the certificate date and corrected manually.

## birth_daypart
Information on whether the child was born before or at noon, or after noon until midnight as stated on the birth certificate.

## birth_hour
Hour of birth as stated on the birth certificate. Hour of birth is standardized and only contains numerical characters.

## birth_place
The place where the child was born as stated on the birth certificate.

## child_sex
Sex of the child as stated on the birth certificate. Sex is standardized and only contains the categories male, female, unreadable, and not available.

## child_fname
Newborn child´s first name as stated on the birth certificate.

## child_prefix
Only the child´s first name is stated on the birth certificate. The child´s surname prefix is constructed based on the following rule: If the father is mentioned on the certificate, the child receives his surname prefix. Otherwise, the child receives his or her mother´s surname prefix.

## child_sname
Only the child´s first name is stated on the birth certificate. The child´s last name is constructed based on the following rule: If the father is mentioned on the certificate, the child receives his last name. Otherwise, the child receives his or her mother´s last name.

## moth_fname
Mother´s first name as stated on the birth certificate.

## moth_prefix
Mothers´ surname prefix as stated on the birth certificate. Incorrectly looking prefixes were corrected manually.

## moth_sname
Mother´s last name as stated on the birth certificate.

## moth_occ
Mother´s occupation as stated on the birth certificate [in Dutch].

## moth_place
Mother´s address as stated on the birth certificate.

## moth_otherinfo
Additional information on the mother as stated on the birth certificate. For instance, it often contains information on the father´s name [in Dutch].

## fath_fname
Father´s first name as stated on the birth certificate. It is derived from the variables inf_otherinfo and moth_otherinfo. As the institution of marriage was not very widespread in Suriname, more than 70% of the certificates do not contain information on the child´s father.

## fath_prefix
Father´s surname prefix as stated on the birth certificate. It is derived from the variables inf_otherinfo and moth_otherinfo. As the institution of marriage was not very widespread in Suriname, more than 70% of the certificates do not contain information on the child´s father.

## fath_sname
Father´s last name as stated on the birth certificate. It is derived from the variables inf_otherinfo and moth_otherinfo. As the institution of marriage was not very widespread in Suriname, more than 70% of the certificates do not contain information on the child´s father.

## witn_fname_1 & witn_fname_2
First name of the first (second) witness as stated on the birth certificate.

## witn_prefix_1 & witn_prefix_2
Surname prefix of the first (second) witness as stated on the birth certificate. Incorrectly looking prefixes were corrected manually.

## witn_sname_1 & witn_sname_2
Last name of the first (second) witness as stated on the birth certificate.

## witn_age_1 & witn_age_2
Age of the first (second) witness as stated on the birth certificate. Impossible ages (for instance 333) were corrected manually.

## witn_occ_1 & witn_occ_2
Occupation of the first (second) witness as stated on the birth certificate [in Dutch].

## witn_place_1 & witn_place_2
Address of the first (second) witness as stated on the birth certificate.

## witn_sig_1 & witn_sig_2
Constructed variable based on whether the first (second) witness was able to sign the birth certificate and whether the first (second) witness was not able to sign the certificate because of illiteracy or for another reason.

## witn_sig_other_1 & witn_sig_other_2
Additional information on the informant´s (in)ability to sign the birth certificate [in Dutch]

## notes_all
All notifications (*kantmeldingen*) added by the clerk on the side of the birth certificate (typically after the certificate was issued) concerning the acknowledgement of the child by his father (*erkenning/wettiging*), name changes (*naamswijziging*), the later death of the child (*overlijden*), and other information (*anders*). Each notification is preceded by its category. If a certificate contains more than one notification, the notifications are separated by "|" [in Dutch].

## B. Work in progress

The current version of the database is work in progress. We are aware that much cleaning still has to be done. In the future, we are planning to improve the current version of the database in the following ways:

- Cleaning and standardizing all the variables referring to occupations and places.

- Cleaning and correcting all the variables referring to first names, prefixes, and last names. This allows us to identify individuals that appear several times in the database and under different roles. Assigning the same individuals unique identifiers will for instance allow to calculate to total number of children by mother and father.

- Add further birth certificates both from Paramaribo (for the incomplete years) and for the districts.

- Ultimately, we aim to link individuals not only within this birth certificates release, but also with the so-called emancipation registers (which are already linked to the slave registers), and the death certificates releases. This will allow to follow individuals and their descendants from slavery (which was abolished in 1863) up until the beginning of the 20$^{th}$ century.